Evaluating Predictive Mental Health Practices

"Decisions fall into the realm of ethics when they pertain to things within our control that can show respect to a human being."

– WEB DuBois

Mental health is a growing global concern, particularly among teens and young adults, as conditions like anxiety and depression rise significantly. In the U.S., mental health issues among young adults have increased over the past decade, with one in five experiencing a mental health disorder each year (National Institute of Mental Health). Mental health challenges take a significant toll on individuals, families, and communities, and addressing them is crucial for improving overall well-being. Governments, healthcare systems, and corporations are developing AI-based prediction tools to address the growing mental health crisis, though accurately predicting mental illness remains challenging due to its complexity. Although I commend UC Berkeley on their exploration of this emerging technology to foster a safer and healthier environment for their students, the proposal by the university falls short in its approach to the sensitive and high-risk subject of mental health by compromising student privacy, diminishing institutional trust, and, most importantly, jeopardizing student safety – contradicting the central aim of the program. I seek to critique this initiative based on these aforementioned values, as well as offer various paths the university can take in order to better align itself with them by making implicit norms explicit and creating catalysts for moving beyond the status quo.

An especially arduous value to reconcile is privacy; The social contract required to participate in a secure and structured community dictates the implicit relinquishing of some

freedoms. Students surrender and expect certain information to be monitored by the university and its subsidiaries. Social media activity, however, does not conform to that category. Many students are ill-informed as to what their online activity can be used for, making their consent to these platforms dubious by default. Furthermore, social media should be a safe space protected by freedom of expression. Algorithms proposed to analyze these sources cannot accurately ascertain every tone and implication of personal messages and posts without an in-depth understanding of the context that an individual's actions stem from. Humor, irony, artistry, and critique risk being misinterpreted by humans, much less algorithms, and, according to leading material on how these algorithms operate, every single piece of information will be analyzed and scored (Marks). Overcoming context restraints also introduces the possibility of further information gathering for the sake of improving accuracy, hinging on more data further removed from the scope of appropriate data flow. Mirroring data collection, moving outside of the consensual scope of data use also induces ethical and practical concerns. Disregarding the possibility of de-anonymization from data, which in itself is undeniably a major privacy issue, health data collected by the university does not transfer consent of its use to any additional third party, especially one with a profit incentive. Many private companies retain the legal right to use purchased data outside of single projects, opening the door for capitalization on recycling the data in other industries such as tenant screening and advertising. The vitality of the student body dictates that these social and industry spheres remain approvably separate; overstepping this boundary will induce adverse mental health effects, nullifying any glimmer of credibility the university seeks to attain from this program by creating a self-fulfilling prophecy.

On the topic of credibility, maintaining student trust in the university not only is paramount to the success of this campaign, but also the success of the university as an institution.

The university already faces an uphill battle in this regard, as an exceptionally large student body and the bureaucracy of departments required to manage it make the emotional component to building trust difficult to obtain. It is not uncommon for a student to see themselves as just a number in the eyes of the university. University advisors bridge this emotional gap by acting as the stewards of connection to the paternalistic institution. However, their abilities are frequently impeded by funding and personnel constraints, which is within good reason. I foresee a scenario of further alienation in executing on algorithmic "risk scores" where the threshold is raised if risk scores average higher than expected, cutting out students who may still need help for the sake of distributing available resources and personnel to the most vulnerable. In this scenario, advisors get overworked and resources get spread thin, potentially prompting a turn to automation in order to alleviate the workload, undermining student faith in university services as a result. Furthermore, students with brief or nonexistent experience with advisors may feel invaded discussing sensitive matters with a stranger, perpetuating the cycle of distrust. As this accumulates, it is not unlikely that students guard themselves against the university by abstaining from volunteering information that they perceive could possibly be misused by the university, resulting in avoiding channels of reporting or even health services for the sake of privacy. Not only does this result in a skewed data set, but it also puts student health at risk. Trust is hard to gain and easy to lose, so scenarios in which it could be eroded must be seriously considered.

Most importantly, if the safety of the students is the greatest motivator of this campaign, the execution on aiding high-risk individuals must be revamped. This criticism begins with the capitalistic priorities of private firms. The motivation of this entity to produce and demonstrate results from empirical data in order to signify the effectiveness of their service raises the possibility of over-executing wellness checks. The decision to involve UCPD opens up

possibilities within the legal arena, as civil servants have obligations to fulfill. Police can and must legally enter residences without warrant due to “exigent circumstances exceptions” that permit enforcement to bypass the fourth amendment if they believe someone to be a danger to themselves or others (Legal Information Institute). That person can be detained, hospitalized, and medicated without consent. Not only does this induce trauma and increase later rates of suicide, but there is documentation on individuals being injured, shot, and killed during the proceedings of wellness checks (Marks; Gerberg, Li). The data used to classify high-risk individuals can skew towards racial, sexual, and disabled demographics, making them most vulnerable to these occasions. The vulnerability of these groups stems from proxies contained in data sets, especially those that consider income, such as work study and financial aid, and preexisting involvement in health service systems such as DSP and SHIP. Trans-identifying individuals require psychological evaluations to receive gender affirming care, low-income individuals frequently enroll in government programs for public health services, and women are more likely to both seek and be diagnosed with mental health complications due to a variety of cultural pressures. All of these cases expose these demographics to both the algorithm and the above safety concerns. This style of execution also perpetuates itself by shifting the blame for negative outcomes onto the university and law enforcement, rather than the private firm responsible for the over-policing. Under this system, the firm has little incentive to alter its practices. Either the firm under-identifies and misses a student, resulting in loss of business, or they over-identify, and the police and university are criticized for what occurs. In this zero-sum game where perfect reporting is impossible, overreporting is the dominant strategy.

There are several recommendations for addressing these criticisms. Comprehensive data-sharing and storage protocols, voluntary opt-ins, and explicit statements of consent for each

layer of the data flow can alleviate privacy tensions. An independent ethics board consisting of data, psychology, and sociology professionals who can audit the processes is a step towards retaining student trust and maintaining private firm involvement and responsibility. For the sake of student safety, funding a specialized UCPD unit trained to resolve mental health engagements is a necessity; If not police, then contacting family, personal physicians or therapists, or other trusted individuals is a better option for “soft touch” interventions. However, if the decision was left solely up to me, I would advocate for allocating the proposed budget to supporting existing university programs that alleviate the development and induction of mental health crises in the first place. Fostering stronger communities by financing clubs, hiring more advisors, enabling greater numbers of enrollment in class selections, improving student amenities, and bolstering existing mental health resources targets the roots of the issue, rather than the symptoms. Due to the inherent personal nature of mental health, diversification of approaches allows for students to find a solution that works for them. Finally, not every issue can be resolved by engineering. This is an uncomfortable truth under the current technocratic paradigm, yet we must admit that engineers alone will not save the world.

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